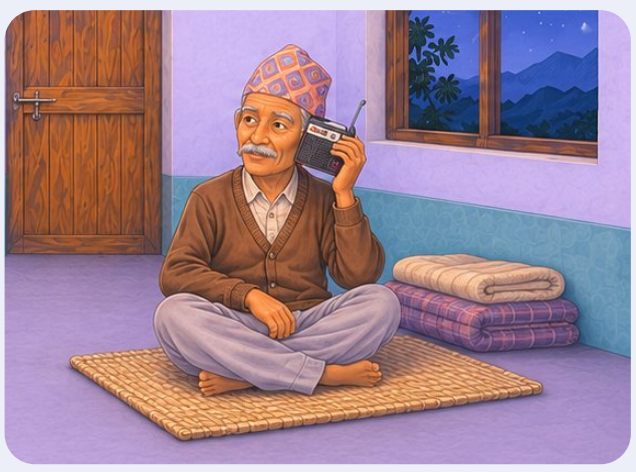
It can be hard to sleep after a distressing experience

After a distressing experience, many people find it hard to sleep. Some wake up afraid, have bad dreams, or lie awake on alert. This is a common reaction. Support can help, and you do not have to wait to ask for it.









1 Before night

- **Know the plan.**
  Check local warnings and know where to go if one comes. Knowing the plan can make it easier to rest.
- **Keep what you need close.**
  A torch, some water, and any medicine you take.
- **Agree on quiet times.**
  In a shared room, agree with the people around you when lights go off and voices go down, if you can.
- **Wind down.**
  A familiar habit before sleep, such as a song, a story or a quiet talk, can help.

2 If you wake up afraid

- **Notice where you are.**
  Look around and name a few things you can see and hear now.
- **Breathe slowly.**
  Breathe in slowly, then breathe out slowly. Stop if it makes you feel worse.
- **Go to someone you trust.**
  Sit with them, or let them know you are awake. You do not have to talk about it.

If you take medicine from a doctor, do not stop it without asking a health worker.

3 Things that can make sleep worse

- **Drinking alcohol or using drugs to sleep**
- **Taking sleeping medicine that a health worker did not give you**
- **Lying awake for a long time going over worries: get up, sit quietly, and try again later**

If there is still danger, follow local warnings. Stay away from unsafe places and damaged buildings.

When to ask for help

If poor sleep goes on and makes your days hard, or you feel very worried about it, talk to a health worker.

Children at night

Children may be afraid of the dark, want to sleep close to you, or start wetting the bed again.

- Let them stay close.
- Keep a short bedtime routine, such as a story or a song.
- Tell them simply what the family will do if a warning comes.
- Do not punish a child for waking up or wetting the bed.

During the day

Get up and eat at regular times if you can, and spend some time in daylight. For more tips on healthy sleep, see the leaflet Healthy sleep (CMC-Nepal).

Ask for help early

Feelings getting worse, not going away, or making daily life hard? Talk to a health worker. You do not have to wait.

Get help now

In danger, or thinking of harming yourself? Get help now. Ask a health worker or responder, and ask someone you trust to stay with you.

Help near you: _____ (filled in and checked locally)

_____

_____

Look after yourself. Look after each other.

Support is for everyone, including people with disabilities and older people. Ask for large print or more time.

Sources: WHO, Psychological First Aid: Guide for Field Workers (2011); WHO/UNHCR, mhGAP Humanitarian Intervention Guide (2015); WHO and UNICEF, Helping children cope with stress (2020); IFRC Psychosocial Centre, Mental health and psychosocial impacts of flooding.

Take-home leaflet · A4 · Chapter 2 of 6 · English review draft · Not for field distribution. Fictional illustrations, AI-assisted and developed under human direction.